finding that over 63 per cent feel that daily household expenses are becoming difficult to manage.

Beside the economy, there are other concerns regarding the state of democracy, with a high 44.7 per cent believing it is in danger, almost equal to those who think it is not. While 50.3 per cent believe that the process of Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls undertaken by the Election Commission of India (ECI) has been fair, a sizeable 37.8 per cent believe that is a politically-biased exercise. They also believe that it is the ECI rather than the Supreme Court which should stop political parties from promising or distributing freebies during elections. The perception that the BJP government, like its predecessors, misuses enforcement agencies like the ED, CBI and IT departments continues to be high.

Despite these negatives, the MOTN findings should serve as a major boost to the prime minister and help him press the pedal on the Reform Express he flagged off in 2025 and possibly even accelerate it to bullet-train speed. The prime minister has begun 2026 with a big bang, as India signed the mother-of-all-trade deals with the European Union. The Modi government should now pursue getting the US to relieve the pressure on tariffs by entering into a win-win trade deal. Domestically, the double-engine sarkars the NDA has accomplished in 21 out of our 31 states/UTs with legislatures need to function more efficiently if the ruling party wants to sustain and even improve its majority.

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Also, the NDA government needs to be seen to deal more even-handedly in Opposition-run states. While the raft of welfare schemes may have reduced the income stress levels among the needy and stabilised the ruling party's political standing, aspirational India wants better-paying jobs and ease of living on the path to a Viksit Bharat. That's why a majority of the MOTN respondents this time have given their approval for the political stability that Modi embodies. ■

Methodology

The INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll was conducted by CVoter, a globally renowned name in the field of socio-economic research, between December 8, 2025, and January 21, 2026, interviewing 36,265 respondents in all Lok Sabha segments across all states. In addition to these samples, an additional 89,714 interviews from CVoter's regular tracker data over the past 24 weeks were also analysed for the long-term trendline in vote and seat projections calculation. Thus, the opinion of a total of 125,979 respondents was considered for this MOTN report. The margin of error is +/- 3 per cent at macro level and +/- 5 per cent at micro level of reporting, with 95 per cent confidence level.

From May 2009 onward, the CVoter Tracker has been carried out each week, 52 waves in a calendar year, in 11 national languages, across all states and UTs in India, with a target sample size of 60,000 samples each quarter. The average response rate is 55 per cent. Starting January 1, 2019, CVoter has been carrying the tracker on a daily basis, using the rollover sample of seven days for tracker analysis.

All these polls are based on a random probability sample as used in the globally standardised methodology, carried out by trained researchers across all geographic and demographic segments. This survey is based on Computer Assisted Telephone Interviews (CATI)of adult respondents across all segments. Standard Random Digit Dialling (RDD) is used to draw random numbers covering all frequency series allocated to all operators across all telecom circles in India.

CVoter ensures proper representative analysis by statistical weighing of the data to make it representative of the local population as per the latest census figures. The data is weighted to the known census profile, including gender, age, education, income, religion, caste, urban/rural and vote recalls for the last Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabha elections. For the analytics, CVoter uses its proprietary algorithm to calculate the provincial and regional vote share based on the split-voter phenomenon.

CVoter follows the code of professional ethics and practices drafted by the World Association of Public Opinion Research and the official guidelines on opinion polling as instructed by the Press Council of India. ■